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Voices of sexual distortion: Rape, birth, and self-annihilation metaphors in the alien trilogy

Thomas Vaughn [a]

[a] Doctoral candidate in the Department of Speech Communication , Indiana University , Bloomington, IN, 47405

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VOICES OF SEXUAL DISTORTION: RAPE, BIRTH, AND SELF-ANNIHILATION METAPHORS IN THE *ALIEN TRILOGY*

Thomas Vaughn

> For whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap. For he that soweth to his flesh, shall of the flesh reap corruption.
> —Galatians 6:7

THE community, insofar as it is constituted through performance, creates the grounds for the lifeworlds of individuals, disseminating the narratives and images we consume and constructing personal universes infused with collective values. Stuart Hall acknowledges the observation by Marx that the "ideas of the past weigh like a nightmare on the brains of the living."[1] Each text arises not from a vacuum, but is dredged from the wells of our collective assumptions and fears. As Antonio Gramsci notes, human nature "is the totality of historically determined social relations" within which cultural ideals become subject to contest.[2] Hall develops this playful notion of hegemony when he writes that ideological chaining may become a site of struggle not only when "people try to displace, rupture or contest it by supplanting it with some wholly new alternative set of terms, but also when they interrupt the ideological field and try to transform its meaning by changing or rearticulating its associations."[3] One of the central ways we strive to assert mass identity is through the creation and reproduction of a cultural mythos. By contesting or deconstructing this mythos, a form of critical dialogue is enacted through the discursive formations of production. Values are thus either placed on trial or standardized in rituals of consumption.

One significant series of texts set in the unstable realm of gender paradigms is the *Alien Trilogy,* a moniker I use to designate the immensely popular films conceived by Ridley Scott. Comprising the trilogy is Scott's *Alien* (1979), James Cameron's *Aliens* (1986), and David Fincher's *Alien*[3] (1992). With the possible exception of *Blade Runner,* these films have drawn more critical attention from film and cultural theorists than any other piece of contemporary science fiction. It is not surprising that almost all of these readings have been informed by some sort of feminist

framework. Rhetorical scholar Janice Rushing is not alone in her analysis of the first two films, arguing that they deal with the repression of essential femininity with a co-opted, patriarchal hero named Ripley (played by Sigourney Weaver).[4] Even though other scholars may not be operating from Rushing's Jungian framework, their analyses tend to read in very similar ways, that some essence of woman is extracted from the female heroine, put on trial through demonization, then ultimately destroyed or chastised.[5] Taking these texts and the academic responses to them into consideration, they become a template for tracing the cultural contest over the meaning of the feminine, especially in relationship to gendered social practices such as motherhood. However, my reading of these texts is not quite as bleak as those just mentioned, for I draw upon the films' critical rather than complacent themes in an attempt to study the traces of power and the representations of social practices contested within the mythopoetic frame. In particular, I hope to elaborate upon the deconstruction of the co-opted feminine subject position through its entanglement with a decomposing metaphor.

A brief explanation of the sequential narrative is in order at this point. In *Alien* we begin on the spaceship Nostromo, a mining vessel that is mysteriously ordered to set down on a desolate planet later called LV426. Exploring the planet, the crew finds a derelict spacecraft fossilized with age, its strange occupants long dead. One member of the landing party is then "infected" by an alien of the same species as those that had exterminated the crew of the ancient craft so long ago. Unaware of their danger they bring the alien on board in embryonic form where, once released, it proceeds to stalk and kill them in a most savage fashion. The ship's doctor, Ash, turns out to be a synthetic person sent along by the "Company" to assure that if something like this is discovered the crew would be unable to kill it, preserving it for the bio-weapons division. Ripley is the only one able to negotiate these dangers, setting the Nostromo for self destruct and jettisoning herself in an escape pod where she has a final conflict with the creature which ends with the alien being blown out of the airlock.

In *Aliens,* special effects epic artist James Cameron (of *Terminator* fame) takes up the story where Ripley is discovered by a deep space salvage team after drifting for almost three decades. Her story is met with disbelief, primarily because LV426 has since been colonized by planetary engineers, sort of the equivalent of American settlers. Only one of the Company's executives believes Ripley's stories, a man of somewhat questionable scruples (Carter Burke) who sends the colonists to investigate the ancient ship. After the Company loses contact with the colony, Ripley then agrees to go back to the planet as an advisor with a platoon of marines. These men and women must then deal with dozens of the creatures and soon meet the same fate as the colonists—extermination. Ripley is able to save one small girl (Newt) and one of the marines (Hicks) by once again battling an alien in space, disposing of it the same way she did the first. This alien is portrayed as a kind of queen, and thus we have the repressed feminine reading.

The last movie becomes as ambiguous as it is depressing. Ripley crashes on a stormy prison planet when the marines' ship mysteriously ejects its occupants. Newt and Hicks are killed. From this incredibly bleak situation she must again watch as the stowaway alien wipes out the prison population, a group of unsavory and desperate men whose foul dispositions are barely kept in check by their monastic religion. To compound matters Ripley finds out that she herself has been infected,

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dooming her to certain death. At movie's end she is able to rally the remaining prisoners to help her foil the Company's attempt to obtain the alien, first by drowning the adult in hot metal and then killing herself along with the embryo she carries.

In the following analysis of these films I trace, in part, Rushing's argument that such movies represent a transformation from the classic frontier narrative, that we have simply traded in our wagons for spaceships.[6] My analysis extends Rushing's by looking for points at which the text collapses upon itself by metaphorically deconstructing this mythic context. Henry Nash Smith argues that during the frontier era the lands beyond the Mississippi were seen as a kind of economic catch-net for the industrial centers of the Northeast. However, the frontier comes under stress as we enter the twentieth century. Thus Smith asks, if "happiness, social harmony, and even liberty itself depended on the presence of free land beyond the frontier, what became of these values in the event that the available land should after all prove to be limited in extent"?[7] It is my contention that the frontier has become the locus of material anxiety, that in a culture so ensconced in the ideologies of consumption this symbol remains the nexus for resolving the tension of property and individuality in the cultural sphere. As the ego evolves within the expansion and constriction of consumer practice, boundaries emerge that define possible identities. Social anxiety erupts within the cultural consciousness when possessed identities become antiquated within the shifting marketplace. These fluctuations may be represented by poetic critiques of reified mythic contexts.

In the first part of this essay I lay out a brief theoretical perspective describing how myth and metaphor function in a dialogic relationship to one another, stitching and tearing the fabric of social reality. I then demonstrate how the *Alien Trilogy* functions as a moment of critical rhetoric by linking gendered practices to an anxiety locked within the mythic context. I complete my analysis by arguing that certain practices associated with the family are indeed being critiqued through such texts and that they represent the struggle of individuals as they attempt to emerge from these ideologies in an environment in which certain practices, such as transcendence through the nuclear family, are no longer seen as necessary or even preferable. In the face of recent hegemonies such as the "family values" campaign and various other breeder ideologies, a critical framework is being laid in the popular culture that allows alternative lifeworlds to emerge. I hope this critique, like certain elements of these texts, will echo as a cry for freedom in the face of perverse homogeneity, moving us a step closer to a new individualism.

Myth, Metaphor, and Subjectivity

> Something is happening to the way
> we think about the way we think.
> —Clifford Geertz

In the position advanced by Peter Berger and Thomas Luckmann, particular experiences may be recounted in such a way that when they are retold or transmitted to other generations, they may become general principles of shared truth. This is the process of sedimentation. In this way the subject "simultaneously externalizes

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his own being into the social world and internalizes it as an objective reality."[8] One of the most cogent examples of how mass-subjectivity may be established with a shared history is identified by Maurice Charland who examines the French independence movement of Quebec where so long as "the *peuple* exists as a subject in history, it is only intelligible within a narrative representation of history."[9] Identity is established mythically and once in place can be reinforced through ritual enactment. William Doty writes that myths can be seen as "expressing lasting nodal points of human significance, the present unquestionable truths, which are considered unfalsifiable so long as sympathetic retelling or ritual reinforcement continues to evoke emotional participation."[10] In relating this to the cultural sphere one might argue that through the repeated consumption of certain genres various ideals are subsequently adopted or rejected. When the ritual remains unbroken, so does identity.

This sets certain problems before the social critic. In Lynn Hinds and Theodore Windt's recovery of the Cold War universe they note that when "certain meanings become associated with names by habitual usage, naming then functions to orient us to situations and people, suggesting appropriate responses or precluding other orientations."[11] This leads to a situation where the mythic reality becomes resistant to change because it has defined the terms that constitute a given culture's perspective. Once this happens, the culture runs the risk of closing off dialogue. An extreme instance of such myopia is presented by Robert Hariman who recites the example of Haili Salassie's court in which courtiers do not have the freedom to wipe dog urine from their boots for fear of breaking with decorum.[12]

The individual may become so unconscious of rhetorical norms that social practices become literalized. Much of the metaphoric theory of Robert Ivie hinges upon the assumption that phenomena "should be considered tentatively from various points of view in order to counter natural tendencies toward the reduction of whole to part" and to resist "literalizing one metaphor to the exclusion of others."[13] Once they lose their poetic potential, metaphors may become as real as any material object. Roland Barthes provides one of the best examples of how critics may draw attention to the most taken-for-granted aspects of their lifeworld, calling to task something as literal as the heartiness of a steak.[14] It thus becomes imperative to the critical task to dislodge subjects from these mythic frames where they may have become shackled.

One way of dislodging subjects in texts is through metaphoric deconstruction. Stephen Daniel writes that "metaphor introduces a dynamic tension into a text" which permits change in interpretation that can lead to shifts in meaning.[15] He argues that certain metaphors function as disruptive devices built into the mythic unity:

> Operative within the discursive formation identified by a myth, and challenging the reign of the mythically organized structure itself, are metaphors, myths-in-miniature. Because the meanings contained within and made determinate by myth are functions of recounting the myth, variations within each recounting literally introduce new and ingenious possibilities for future communicative significance.[16]

This is similar to Burke's notion of "perspective by incongruity" which critiques by "exemplifying relationships between objects which our customary rational vocabulary has ignored."[17] The poetic in the mythopoetic thus becomes the element that breaks down these reified mythic structures. This can be seen in such monovocal

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realms as philosophy which Jacques Derrida argues is reliant upon literalized metaphors, comparing them to "the *original figure* of the coin which has been worn away (usé), effaced, and polished in the circulation of the philosophical concept."[18] Paul De Man notes the same effect when critiquing ontological discussions where "tropological patterns reenter the system in the guise of such formal categories as polarity, recurrence, normative economy, or in such grammatical tropes as interrogation."[19] Poetic elements become literalized through use, but may swim like sharks beneath the surface of a text, only to emerge within the narrative frame when summoned by some material stress.

We can see this elucidated in the work of Paul Ricoeur who posits the notion of the "split referent" which entails "the paradox of the copula, where being-as signifies being and not being" simultaneously within a transfer between literal and figurative meaning.[20] He then notes that it is in "the other [metaphoric] field that the energy capable of achieving this uprooting and this transference resides."[21] The habitat of metaphor is within the difference between the grammatical fields of reference, and it is within this gap, this moment of ambiguity, that social change becomes not only a possibility, but a necessity. Ricoeur argues that it is this tension that "contributes concretely to the epoche of ordinary reference and to the projection of new possibilities of redescribing the world."[22] Both David Klope and David Procter have examined the way myths reconcile moments of ambiguity in American consciousness, illustrating how it serves to smooth contradictions without changing the national identity.[23] The present focus, however, will be on how ambiguity "produces" rather than sustains community, creating the grounds for meaningful shifts in mass-consciousness.

Myth and Metaphor in the *Alien Trilogy*

> My soul lives in this body
> of mine as in a purgatory.
> —Catherine of Genoa

Hopefully, I have clarified my views upon the interaction of metaphor and myth and the function of ambiguity within dominant discourse frames. To facilitate my critique of these texts I have identified three metaphoric clusters that dissolve the narrative, thus dispersing the subject. This is not to say that these are the only clusters which produce a viable reading of these films, but they are the most useful for tracing the deconstruction of the family ideology presently under scrutiny. The metaphoric ambiguity is achieved through images of rape, birth, and self-annihilation. Through these figurative fields, the restless text is made a little more apparent and the emancipatory function may be articulated. After I have elaborated upon the disruptive nature of these elements, I will complete my analysis by redescribing this notion of the rhetorical subject.

Rape

According to Claude Levi-Strauss, the process of myth is often designed to facilitate the fusion of seemingly disparate terms—to collapse, for example, dichoto-

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mies such as "carnivore" and "herbivore" under the single term "coyote."[24] It is quite obvious in the *Alien Trilogy* that Ripley is being constructed in opposition to the alien, stating at one point in *Alien*[3], "You've been in my life so long, I can't remember anything else." All other characters prove mortal within the sequential narrative; only Ripley and the hostile species remain constant. As has been noted, the primary way to read this opposition has been through the feminist paradigm. Jeffords sums up this effort by noting the lack of solidarity among female characters:

> Women in these films, having nothing in common but the fight with the alien, something they share with all the men as well. The feature that identifies them as distinct from men—their shared history of reproduction—is that which they are most set to destroy in the image of the alien and of which they are most afraid.[25]

Much of the evidence for this reading is drawn from *Aliens* where Ripley must confront the egg-laying queen, even referring to it as a "bitch" at one point. Creed writes that in "the final scenes of *Aliens* we confront the mother alien—a monstrous, deadly, procreative machine, prepared to protect her young at all costs—primitive, amoral, female."[26] Thus the gender identity is defined in essentialist terms, biological woman pitted against co-opted, technocratic woman.

However, metaphors of rape and desire set about the task of problematizing this dualism. Rushing informs our discussion in the way in which she positions these movies in relationship to the frontier context:

> *Aliens* demonstrates that the frontier is again evolving, but only into a hybrid of the old and new myths, in which the lost feminine is encountered, found to be vengeful at the exploitation of her domain, and then killed by a patriarchalized heroine.[27]

The alien becomes the savage element lurking in the primeval realm of space, that which masculine technology must overcome to exploit and rape its resources (i.e., virgin space). Robin Roberts writes that through "her primal utterances, the alien reveals that she represents a pre-symbolic mothering, for she is pre-verbal."[28] Technology seeks to penetrate and control the primitive "nature" of space of which the alien is a part. In contrast, I argue that technology is also portrayed as trying to seal off rather than penetrate. For example, the motion detectors carried by the marines, the primary tool of suspense in *Aliens*, form a sensor perimeter around the marines which the aliens then invade, leaving all attempts to resist or detect their approach in vain. Even the machinery of the colony itself is penetrated by the slimy secretions of the aliens, blending cog with sinew. Further, insofar as the aliens need a human host to breed, humans become their resource, that which they exploit. Rather than a passive rape of the frontier, both alien and corporation violate one another.

This is embodied visually in the most stunning way through the first-stage aliens, small crab-like creatures that emerge from eggs, attach themselves to the victim's face, then inseminate them. Cain, the member of the crew of the Nostromo who gets infected, is attacked in the most startling fashion as the creature flies from its egg and penetrates his space helmet. In *Aliens*, when the marines first arrive at the colony, they find some of these creatures in large vats of fluid where they had been studied by the now dead colonists. When Carter Burke gets close to one of the tanks, the creature suddenly attacks the glass, its penis-like tube straining to reach him.

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One of the marines behind him states mockingly, "Looks like love at first sight. Oh, he likes you, Burke." Later in the movie Burke turns these creatures loose in the room with Ripley and Newt, hoping to infect them and later sneak their bodies through quarantine on the way back as a means of getting ahead in the Company. The single-mindedness of these creatures is astonishing as they immediately locate Ripley and attempt to "rape" her, one of them wrapping its tail around her neck and trying to force its phallic dispenser down her throat.

What we see developing is a reciprocal rather than one-way rape, that the aliens are in fact cross-gendered. This can be seen in the last scene of *Alien* when the creature stows away on the escape pod with Ripley. Ripley, who had recently disrobed for hyper-sleep, puts on a vac-suit while being complimented with a most suggestive camera angle as the alien watches her from a crevice in the wall. In her classic treatise on women in the cinema, Laura Mulvey argues that females are presented for the male spectator as objects of desire rather than as characters who actively advance the narrative.[29] The alien takes on the male role of voyeur to her near nudity in this scene, watching her movements with a masculine intensity.

Even as an adult it is difficult to argue that the alien represents essential femininity. Harvey Greenberg is almost beside himself when he describes it, writing that it reflects the "charnel house aesthetic of the medieval dance of death; the hellish apparitions of Bosch, the figurations of Tibetan demonology."[30] The aliens seem assembled, possessing a jet-black metallic surface which makes it difficult to tell if it is mechanical (male) or biological (female). By disrupting the gender image to which Ripley is set in opposition, it becomes difficult to grasp and maintain a fix on her identity. We might locate an exit from this quandary by acknowledging the French feminist's post-structural/psychoanalytic move to associate the type of contradiction represented by the alien with essential femininity. Note the following passage from Hélène Cixous:

> A woman's body with its thousand and one thresholds of ardor—once, by smashing yokes and censors, she lets it articulate the profusion of meanings that run through it in every direction—will make the old single-grooved mother tongue reverberate with more than one language.[31]

Yet the alien is not pure feminine irrationality set in opposition to masculine rationality. Michel Foucault writes that in madness the totality "of soul and body is parceled out; not according to the elements which constitute that totality metaphysically; but according to figures, images which envelope segments of the body and ideas of the soul in a kind of absurd unity."[32] These elements "isolate man from himself, but above all from reality."[33] The phallic imagery of the alien does not serve to reaffirm the gender dichotomy, but to deconstruct it. Exciting though it is, the ardor of the Medusa is still predicated upon a metaphysic that inhibits any such critique.

The reciprocity of rape establishes a multi-channel and variant flow of sexual meaning. Through the disruption of gender positions within the alien, the conclusion that Ripley is simply a co-opted hero becomes somewhat problematic. This is not to say that a feminist reading of the movie is wrong, but that a focus upon ambiguity calls for a revised critical stance to the movies, that the gender identity goes beyond a simple paradigm of repressed "other."

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Birth

It already has been noted that these films have been viewed as pitting one woman against another. *Aliens* is especially infamous for the images of motherhood it evokes with the queen alien on the one hand, and Ripley and Newt on the other. As we have seen, most of the authors view this as patriarchal co-optation, except for Roberts who sees the film as celebrating adoptive parenting (Ripley) over biological (alien).[34] This did not go unnoticed by the popular press as we see with David Edelstein celebrating Ripley as the "Mother of the Year."[35] Thus, any discussion of the movies that fails to address the reproductive imagery cannot help but be incomplete.

The process of birth, in its biological essence, is specifically singled out for demonization. The aliens emerge from slimy eggs in the form of crab-like inseminators which attach themselves to the face. They cannot be removed because they either kill the victim or bleed a corrosive acid that can eat through the hull of a ship. After the implantation is complete, they simply drop off and die. Later, the host is racked by stomach pains, enduring the agony of having the creature explode through their abdomen. The creature then rapidly grows to about six to ten feet in length at which point it becomes a killing machine. When enough of these creatures are present to form a nest, one takes the role of egg-layer and thus the process comes full circle.

The movies themselves become metaphors for the birth process, but in a special way. Space would seem an excellent place to shoot the western myth in wide open panorama style. However, the majority of these movies take place in near darkness and in very claustrophobic conditions. *Alien* is shot in narrow corridors filled with steam and dripping water, *Aliens* in red-light with sinews covering the walls, and *Alien*[3] in the murky depression of the prison. Not surprisingly, the nesting place for the aliens is associated with the womb by Jeffords who writes that it is a "deadly place, threatening to absorb humans into its pulsating walls and consume them with its acidic hunger."[36] The ships and the colonies become almost oppressive bodies, searching to devour those within. The frontier has not grown into a place of fertility, but through the reversal of the womb metaphor, becomes hungry and savage. That which once produced, now consumes.

In classical mythology, Joseph Campbell notes that birth is a form of transcendence, of linear character development where a progressive frame is established.[37] One does not sense any such release in the *Alien Trilogy*. The characters flee from one murky room to the next, never safe, never sure where the danger lurks. Jane Goodall writes that "organic interaction with the environment . . . is achieved by anatomical systems of opening and closure, so technological control is manifest in the proliferation of devices for sealing off and gaining entry."[38] The marines in *Aliens* continuously move from room to room, throwing up technological barriers as they go, but are never able to escape. With the mixture of biological and technological images, the characters seemed trapped within a loop of savage reproduction that systematically deconstructs the linear nature of birth described by Campbell.

The concluding scenes of the three movies will play a greater role in the subsequent analysis, but suffice to say that the first two attempt to transcend with a triumphant expulsion of an alien from a ship's airlock. Human and alien remain incommensurable within this environment, this loop. The double-bind is only transcended with the ejection of one from the mythic scene. This cleansing is,

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however, ephemeral as the creature returns with fury in subsequent movies. It is important to note that much of the critical impact of the *Alien Trilogy* is apprehended when the films are viewed collectively as a cultural phenomenon rather than treating them individually. The critique of the ambiguity becomes particularly apparent when the first two are read through the third. By continually foiling the linear movement of the birth image, of permanent transformation, the circularity of the process disposes with the finality of any *telos,* dislodging the subject from its prescribed direction.

Self-Annihilation

Fredric Jameson notes that texts may present the reader with an *aporia.* This "conceptual scandal is what accounts for the restless life of the system, its desperate attempts to square its own circles and to produce new terms out of itself which ultimately solve the dilemma at hand."[39] As some material conflict with the text's ideology presents itself to the mind, the text itself will seek to overcome the paradox through the process of narrative closure. Much of this is accomplished in the first two movies by expelling the alien from the *polis,* saving society from the savage frontier. Robert Wood writes that "a partition is established between human and alien life which allows us to perceive the threat as external. The human body is no longer threatening to itself."[40] The text, in effect, embodies biological reproduction through the alien, then literally (alien)ates us from it with images of a demonized body. The critical move is made in the third movie where subject dislocation occurs through themes of self-annihilation.

The prime *aporia* is really quite interesting. After she has been picked out of hyper-space in *Aliens,* Ripley tries to warn the Company that they must take seriously the threat that these creatures pose to civilization, spouting at her debriefing that "if just one of those things gets down here then this, all this bullshit you think is so important (seizing a handful of papers), well you can just kiss all that good-bye." Yet the Company remains blind to the destructiveness of the aliens as the themes of exploitation become more overt. In *Alien*^{3}, Ripley is able to rally the prisoners against the Company by arguing that if you are going to die anyway, why not do it while saving humanity by killing the last of these organisms and keeping it away from the Company. The prime irony is that the Company is attempting to exploit its own destruction, that it is courting its own suicide. Goodall discusses the relationship between the Company and the alien as basically one of domination, but that "whatever of moist nature has been sterilized and subjugated by the demiurgical powers of the technocrats, the devouring principle has always been there, at the center of their activity."[41] Successful cultivation of the alien as resource, which is the teleological commitment of the Company, means extermination of the human race. They wish to exploit and market death. The frontier remains informative to our analysis through its articulation of American anxiety in the realm of the marketplace which, in this case, is larded with both a valuable and a violent currency revolving around reproductive practice.

Alien^3 functions critically in this context by steadily erasing Ripley's conventional hero status. One of the first ways this is achieved is with the partial erasure of her identity. In the prison colony, all of the men wear shaved heads to reduce the occurrence of lice. Once among them, Ripley unflinchingly complies with this

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standard. This is certainly a far cry from the objectified item of desire she becomes at the end of *Alien,* reducing the stature of her sexuality by homogenizing her with the male prison population. What is interesting is that it is at this point that she is realized sexually, something that has not been an issue in the narratives of any of the previous movies. She copulates with the prison doctor in a most unceremonious, off-screen, and matter-of-fact encounter. The first time we ever see her sexuality emerge is at the point that her identity as an "attractive woman" has been erased. *Telos* is realized through the act of subject annihilation.

The film also plays with audience expectations of character longevity. In the first two movies we identify with a small body of crew members throughout most of the narrative. In *Alien*[3], however, the warden and the doctor, the two who we would think might make it, are two of the first to be killed, thus forcing us to re-identify with a new ensemble. What is most critical though is Ripley's suicide. After running an ultra-sound on herself she realizes that one of the creatures is inside her. By movie's end, this is the last fragment of the alien species encountered on LV426, and thus the company tries very hard to obtain her. She sits perched above a vat of molten metal with Company people all around her trying to coax her down. At this point she executes her climactic swan dive into the vat, killing both herself and the embryo just as it emerges. During her slow-motion fall its hoary head emerges from her abdomen as she gently caresses it as a mother might caress an infant, her face overcome with an ambiguous calm. The transcendence of the double-bind occurs not within the reaffirmation of the hero, but with her elimination. The *telos,* insofar as it has been linked to the heroic subject, is subverted.

IMPLICATIONS

My discussion began with a reference to Hall and the use of cultural chains as sites of conflict. This becomes particularly acute in discussions of the consumer sphere, the emancipatory power of which has been overlooked. Colin Campbell notes that paradigms of modern hedonism not only make it possible to understand precisely how a consumer "creates (and abandons) wants, and why it is that this has become a never-ending process, but also directs attention to the character of consumption as a voluntaristic, self-directed and creative process in which cultural ideals are necessarily implicated."[42] Consumption becomes analogous to identification in that it implies the ritual engagement with certain products that entail certain values. In his critique of Habermas' attack on the consumer culture, Michael Warner writes that where "consumer capitalism makes available an endlessly differentiable subject, the subject of the public sphere cannot be differentiated."[43] Within the cultural chum of the late twentieth century it becomes difficult to articulate exactly what our common identity is and this, I would argue, leads to more freedom for interpretation among individuals. The destabilization of *telos* in the *Alien Trilogy* functions to enhance this dislocation by critiquing cultural practices associated with gender.

In her discussion of gender and archetypes, Estella Lauter makes an interesting claim:

> If archetypal images mark the places (intersections) where the gap between "inner" and "outer" becomes visible—that is, if they represent persistent problems of human experience—then the images of the goddess mark recurrent questions about female experiences rather than essential characteristics of Woman.[44]

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Rather than looking for some essential unity within the mythic structure that totalizes identity, the poetic directs us to explore the shifting experience of gender within our culture. Jeffords notes that *Aliens* represents a "revised notion of the nuclear family; strong nurturing mother, sensitive wounded father, and battered but enduring child."[45] Indeed when Ripley saves Newt and Hicks from the colony it appears as if we have transcended into a god term, that of "family." Ripley has correctly found her place as mother and has thus overcome the tension within the mythic frame. However, in the *Alien Trilogy*, the frontier emerges again and again until we have heroic erasure with Ripley's fetishized suicide.[46] Any attempt by her to establish an identity that can overcome the savage frontier is precluded by her ultimate inability to realize herself through any conventional identity. The text's answer: destroy the "conventional" subject.

I consider this analysis part of a much broader project that will seek to analyze the critique of breeder culture in America. Rituals of marriage and reproduction have become so instantiated within the community that often any rejection of these practices is viewed as pathological. We have seen a trend that one might identify as the "fascism of the family." When politicians or activists wish to censor cultural dialogue in some way, they often argue something to the effect of "Well, we must think about our children. How will they react to this message? They must come first." The response of the non-breeding individual might be to say, "What do you mean our children? I don't have any children." This is not intended in any way to indict individuals who have elected to engage in conventional reproductive practice, but simply to acknowledge the fact that this ideology has been used as a justification for the erasure of subaltern religions and lifeworlds, defining job status, and justifying taxation practices. The idea that it is natural for humans to reproduce and assume certain roles in relationship to a child that hinge upon gender is perhaps one of the most literal ideologies currently active. Such texts as the *Alien Trilogy* may create the ground for a richer discussion of the critical explosions within the culture that seek to undo, to denaturalize, this mythic frame. The way this is done in the present text is to locate a deconstructive anxiety in the economic context of the frontier. In a species whose technological "developments" have all but erased death, we now threaten to destroy ourselves with our own success. Is it any wonder that reproduction now emerges as the demonized other? We may be facing the possibility that the family is no longer a financial asset, but instead a significant burden that ties individuals to anything from a reified role such as mother or husband to some corporate hierarchy now inescapable due to social responsibility. This possibility, as unpleasant as it might seem, is one that rhetorical critics must take seriously.

Through the ambiguity of the *Alien Trilogy*, the individual may be saved by its own annihilation. This is not some dissent into chaos or a complete erasure of identity, but a celebration of the rhetoricity of the social environment. Raymie McKerrow notes that within a critical rhetoric, the subject may shift ground without being either completely determined by the mode of production or constituted as a sovereign entity.[47] This move thus embraces the contingent nature of social reality, leaving the individual free to move through and between specific ideologies. To understand this, one might refer to the work of Kent Ono and John Sloop who argue that *telos* should be refigured as a purposive and contingent ideal rather than an absolute.[48] Postmodern performance has opened the ground for new possibilities

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regarding the individual, allowing it to select between power poles rather than being forced either to conform or not conform. This we might call the "new individualism" with its ego that embraces, if ever so tentatively, the illusion of freedom.

NOTES

Thomas Vaughn is a doctoral candidate in the Department of Speech Communication, Indiana University, Bloomington, IN 47405. *This paper was developed with help from Robert Ivie and Barbara Klinger of Indiana University. The author wishes to thank these scholars, the reviewers, and John Lucaites for his insights in developing the broader theoretical project relating to this work. The author also wishes to thank Tom Frentz, Janice Rushing, and Frank Scheide for their support of his pursuit of film criticism.*

[1]Stuart Hall, "Signification, Representation, and Ideology: Althusser and the Post-Structural Debates," *Critical Studies in Mass Communication* 2 (1985): 111.

[2]Antonio Gramsci, *Selections From the Prison Notebooks,* Trans. Quintin Hoare and Geoffrey Smith (New York: International, 1971) 133.

[3]Hall 112.

[4]Janice Rushing, "Evolution of *The New Frontier* in *Alien* and *Aliens:* Patriarchal Co-optation of the Feminine Archetype," *Quarterly Journal of Speech* 75 (1989): 19.

[5]See for example Barbara Creed, "*Alien* and the Monstrous-Feminine," *Alien Zone: Cultural Theory and Contemporary Science Fiction Cinema,* Ed. Annette Kuhn (New York: Verso, 1990) 128–41; Susan Jeffords, "The Battle of the Big Mamas: Feminism and the Alienation of Women," *Journal of American Culture* 10/3 (1987): 73–84.

[6]Janice Hocker Rushing, "Mythic Evolution of *The New Frontier* in Mass Mediated Rhetoric," *Critical Studies in Mass Communication* 3 (1986): 265–96.

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[21]Ricoeur 299.

[22]Paul Ricoeur, "The Metaphorical Process as Cognition, Imagination, and Feeling," *Critical Inquiry* 5 (1978): 152.

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[24]Claude Levi-Strauss, "The Structural Study of Myth," *Journal of American Folklore* 68 (1955): 441.

[25]Jeffords 80.

[26]Barbara Creed, "Gynesis, Postmodernism, and the Science Fiction Horror Film," in Kuhn 215.

[27]Rushing "Evolution of *The New Frontier,*" 19.

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